

User's Manual

Introduction

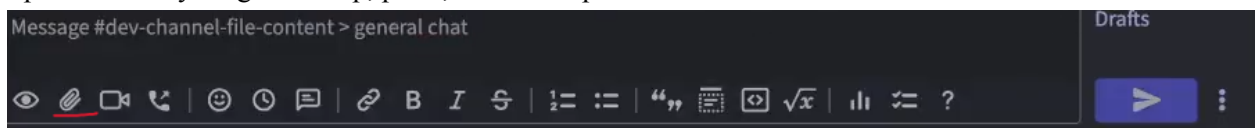
This user manual explains how to use the file-content search feature in Zulip. This feature allows you to search and filter relevant files by file content using the Zulip search bar. It supports text extraction for several text-based files, including txt, pdf, and docx as well as image-based files, including png, jpg, and image-based pdfs. This document walks you through the complete process of uploading files and retrieving relevant files by file content.

Uploaders

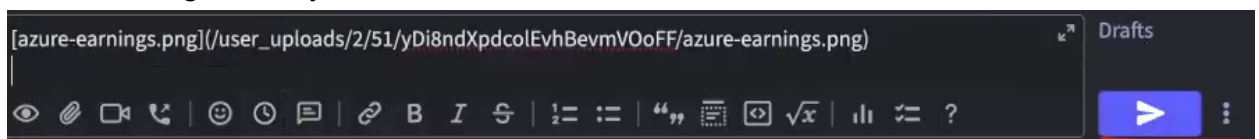
Uploaders do not use a special upload flow for searchable documents. The same UI is used for any attachment that also triggers content extraction. Therefore, there are technically no changes from the uploaders' side.

An example existing usage of the upload flow:

1. Upload a file by drag-and-drop, paste, or the compose box attachment button.



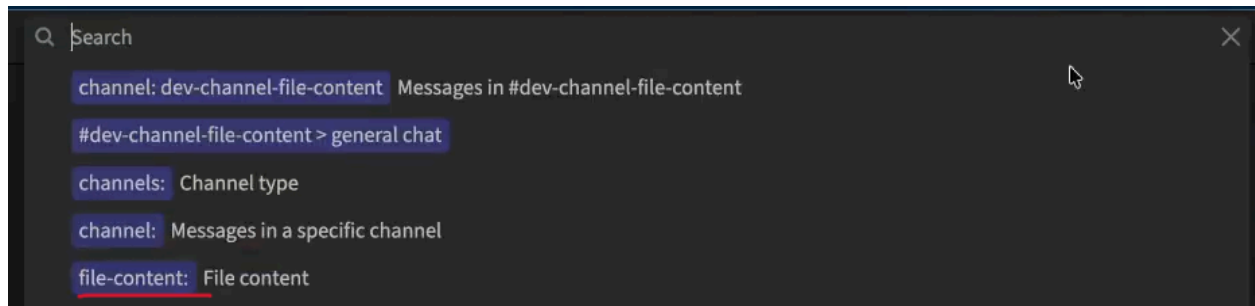
2. Send the message normally.



The asynchronous worker that is running in the background will automatically start extracting the file's contents.

Readers

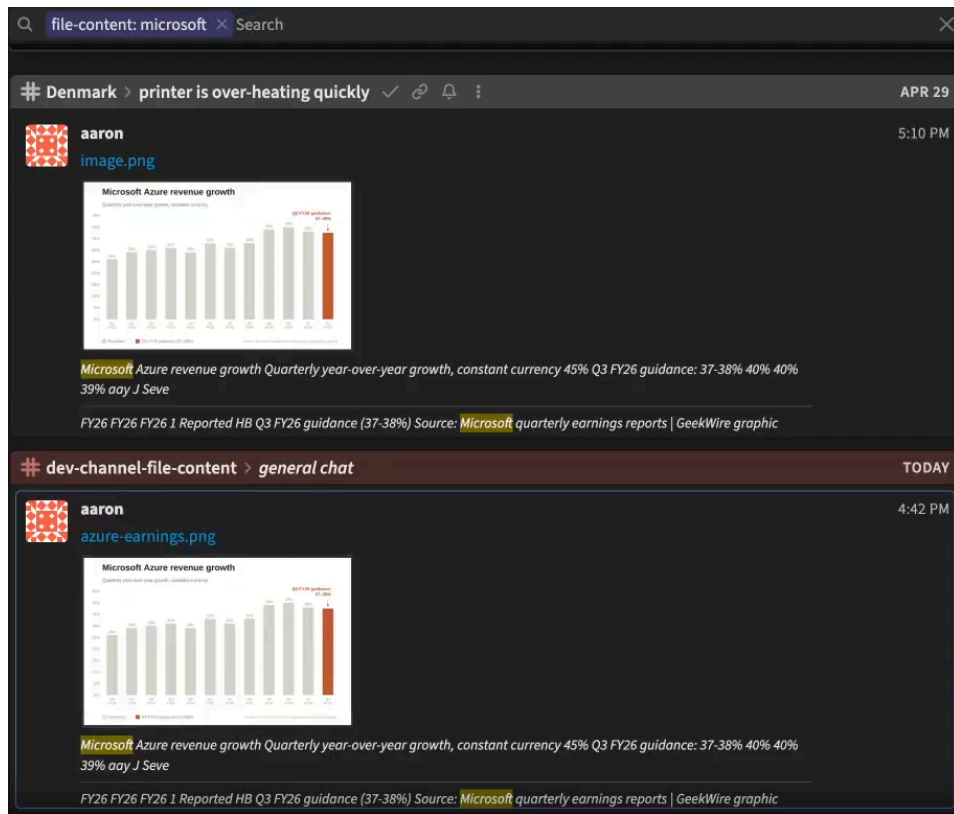
Readers access the capability entirely through Zulip's existing search box. The web app search suggestions expose `file-content:` as a normal search filter. This filter is integrated with the existing Zulip workflow so it inherits all the features of the search tags such as chaining. All matching results will be displayed, similar to the existing search bar results. Matched words in the query will be highlighted in the result from an excerpt in the files.



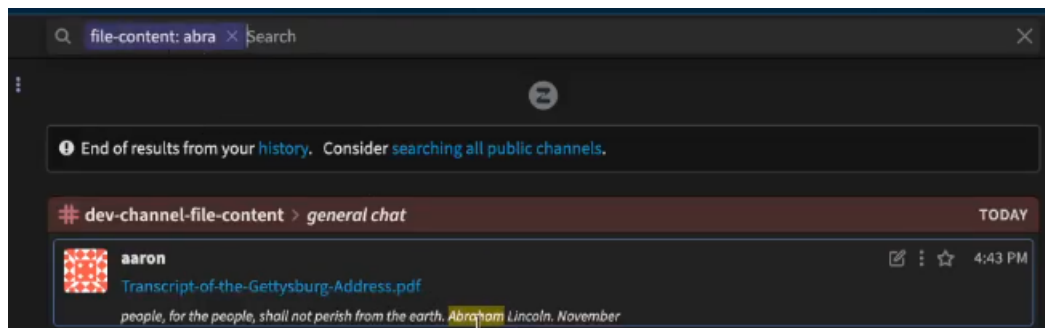
Common usages:

Purpose	Query	Result
Find a document by keyword	file-content:microsoft	All supported files that contain the word microsoft will be displayed in the search results and the word microsoft will be highlighted.
Search within one channel	channel:discussion file-content:result	All supported files within the discussion channel that contain the word result will be displayed in the search results and the word result will be highlighted.
Search for multiple words	file-content:"quarterly report"	All supported files that contain the word quarterly or report will be displayed in the search results and the words will be highlighted
Search for a partial word	file-content:cont	All supported files that contain the pre/suffix letters cont will be displayed in the search results and any word that contain this pre/suffix cont will be highlighted

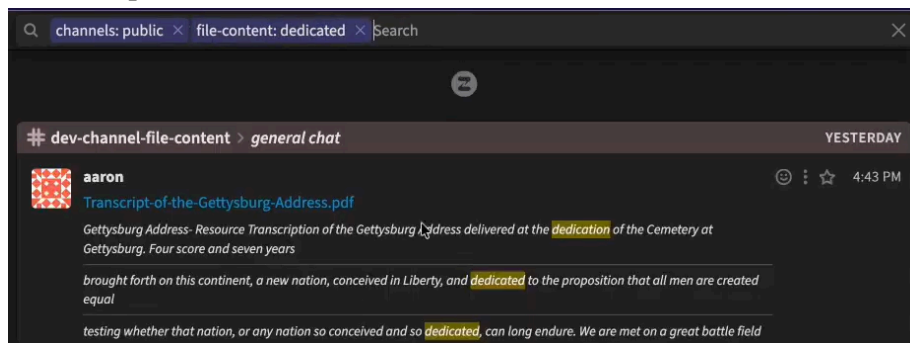
Single word search screenshot:



Partial word search screenshot:



Channel specified word search screenshot:



Administrators

Administrators do not need to perform any additional configuration to enable the file-content search feature. There are no additional features for the administrators of the channels other than letting the channel know that such a feature exists.

Troubleshooting

If relevant results do not show after a valid file-content search, it could be due to several factors:

1. If search is performed immediately after upload, it is likely due to the asynchronous text extraction in the background. Extraction should be fast most of the time, but in the case of a large file, try again in a few minutes.
2. If results do not show after a long time, it is likely due to an unsupported file type other than txt, pdf, docx, jpg, png or poor quality text (e.g. handwritten or blurry). The content extraction only supports well-formatted text.